by a shared identity that went beyond caste, religious and other divisions. Another urgent concern was the crushing poverty and economic deprivation most Indians faced. Nehru's belief in socialism led him to emphasize the government's role in empowering people to rise out of poverty. These ideas of India came to underpin the principles of the Constitution as well as the government's policies after 1947.



The Cold War is the name of the period of global tension between the democratic United States of America and the communist Soviet Union (and their allies). This tension determined how countries related to each other, what wars they fought and whom they gave aid to. Rather than align with one or the other, Nehru believed India would be best served by remaining non-aligned and thus retain its independence.

An indelible legacy

Nehru remains India's longest-serving prime minister—he was in office for nearly eighteen years before his death. During that time, he often worked seventeen-hour days and made it a point to participate in parliamentary discussions and answer questions on his policies. He thus fostered a respect for and trust in the mechanisms of democracy. He also supported the founding of long-lasting institutions in the areas of science, technology and